

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- The DfE's updated academy trust handbook made a £174,000 cap on academy trust chief executive pay binding from 1 October — any new post advertised above it, or any performance bonus above £25,000, now needs government approval, and trusts have been told not to assume a departing boss's salary carries over to their successor.

→ **For your school:** Not an issue for most schools, but trust-level finance and HR leads should check any CEO recruitment already under way against the new approval process.

- ASCL told Tes its 'scope for negotiation is exhausted' on Ofsted's impact on leader wellbeing, with its council meeting this week to decide on 'more assertive action' — education secretary Lucy Powell has responded by admitting in writing that the current system is 'high-stakes and low-trust'.

→ **For your school:** Nothing to change yet, but worth watching — if ASCL escalates further it could speed up the framework review Powell flagged last week.

- The DfE added 35 funded educational psychologist training places for 2026 entry, lifting the national total from 204 to 239, though the profession's own body says it's still far short of what SEND reform will demand.

→ **For your school:** Flag the AEP's funded-training route to any staff considering it — applications typically close in late November.

- Sheffield signed up to a near-90-council scheme to tackle NEET numbers in the same week that High Storrs became the city's top-rated secondary under Ofsted's stricter framework — two sharply different signals about the city's schools landing almost together.

→ **For your school:** Useful context for careers leads and SLT discussing post-16 destinations data at this term's governors' meeting.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

16 Oct 2026 — Sheffield's Year 7 secondary school application deadline for September 2027 entry closes.

16 Oct 2026 — Teachers' 2026 pay determination document expected to be laid before Parliament (LGA-estimated date).

28 Oct 2026 — Final deadline for academies and local authorities to submit autumn school census returns.

6 Nov 2026 — Deadline for schools and colleges to request changes to their 2027-28 high needs place numbers, or 2026-27 figures roll over by default.

■ NATIONAL POLICY

- **£174,000 academy trust CEO pay cap becomes binding.** From 1 October, the updated academy trust handbook requires DfE approval before any newly advertised chief executive post pays above £174,000, or any performance bonus exceeds £25,000 — explicitly modelled on NHS-style pay controls. Trusts have also been told not to assume a departing CEO's salary simply transfers to their successor. Schools Week's own analysis found 182 trusts paid their chief executive above the new threshold last year, and

ASCL's Pepe Di'lasio has already criticised the flat cap for ignoring trust size and London weighting — a two-school primary MAT faces the same ceiling as a 20-school secondary one. ([Schools Week](#))

→ **For your school:** No action for most schools, but trust boards with a CEO recruitment or succession already in progress should check it against the new sign-off process now.

■ FUNDING

■ **NASUWT demands clarity on how the 3.5% teacher pay rise is actually funded.** Reported Wednesday, the union says the government's claim that this year's pay award is covered by revaluing the Local Government Pension Scheme doesn't add up, because those pension savings were already built into school budgets — meaning schools may be left to find the money themselves. The DfE insists it's confident schools can cover the award nationally and won't claw back the savings, but NASUWT wants the original funding table republished in full. It's the same anxiety about who absorbs cost pressures running through this week's CEO pay story above. ([Personnel Today](#))

→ **For your school:** Stress-test this term's budget against the funding assumptions NASUWT is disputing before committing further spend.

■ **High needs place numbers: act by 6 November or lose the chance to change them.** This week's DfE Update for academies confirms that schools and colleges must contact their local authority now if their 2027-28 high needs place numbers need to change — if no request is made, 2026-27 figures simply roll over and determine next year's funding allocation. It's a quieter companion to the autumn census deadline (also in the diary this week), both feeding the same funding pipeline. ([GOV.UK \(DfE Update academies, 7 October 2026\)](#))

→ **For your school:** Confirm with your SENCo and finance lead whether specialist place numbers need updating before 6 November.

■ INCLUSION & SEND

■ **DfE adds 35 funded educational psychologist training places.** The increase, from 204 to 239 places nationally for 2026 entry, lands as councils prepare for SEND reforms including the proposed 'experts at hand' service, which will lean heavily on EP capacity. The Association of Educational Psychologists welcomed it as 'an important first step' but pointed to continuing shortages — Schools Week has previously reported that close to nine in ten applicants for DfE-funded courses were turned away last year (a figure worth treating as approximate, since take-up varies by cohort). It's a small but genuine move against a workforce bottleneck that shapes how quickly schools can get EHCP assessments done. ([Schools Week / Association of Educational Psychologists](#))

→ **For your school:** Worth flagging to your SENCo as context for ongoing EP waiting times, and to any staff weighing up the funded training route.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

■ **ASCL says 'scope for negotiation is exhausted' on Ofsted and leader wellbeing.** The union's council met this week to weigh 'more assertive action' after what general secretary Pepe Di'lasio called a lack of progress addressing the damage inspections do to leaders' wellbeing. In a written response, education secretary Lucy Powell conceded the current system is 'high-stakes and low-trust' and that she wants one that is 'more supportive and, crucially, recognises the context' schools work in. That directly builds on last week's story about Powell planning Ofsted changes 'within the next few months' — NAHT's push and now ASCL's escalation suggest that timeline is under real pressure to move faster. ([Tes](#))

→ **For your school:** Nothing to action yet, but worth watching closely — a union escalation here could pull any framework change forward.

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

■ **A genuinely quiet week for behaviour and attendance data — no new national release landed.** The most recent picture is still FFT Education Datalab's full-year 2025/26 analysis published in September, which found suspensions continuing to ease back from their 2023/24 peak, with secondary year groups (especially Years 9 and 10) driving the fall — but primary showing a small rise against the trend. No

comparable new figures emerged this week, so this stays the operative picture for now rather than being superseded. (FFT Education Datalab)

→ **For your school:** *If your own primary behaviour data is moving against the national secondary trend, it's worth a look before assuming the sector-wide improvement applies to you too.*

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

▪ **World Mental Health Day (Saturday 10 October) gives this week a pastoral hook.** Most schools will mark it on Friday given the weekend date. This year's global theme is reported by the World Federation for Mental Health as 'Lived Experiences Heard: Real Voices, Real Change', though WHO's own campaign page wasn't independently verifiable at the time of writing, so treat the exact wording with some caution. It lands weeks after KCSIE 2026 explicitly stopped treating mental health concerns as separate from safeguarding — a PSHE assembly or wear-green day this week is as much a safeguarding touchpoint as a wellbeing one under the new guidance. (World Federation for Mental Health / WHO campaigns page)

→ **For your school:** *Check whether your PSHE lead has a Friday activity planned, and remind staff that mental-health changes in a pupil now sit under KCSIE 2026's safeguarding lens, not a separate pastoral one.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **High Storrs becomes Sheffield's top-rated secondary under Ofsted's new framework.** Published Wednesday, the report gave the Bents Green school, run by Minerva Learning Trust, a 'strong standard' rating across all inspected areas — praising pupils' confidence, extracurricular clubs, leadership and above-average attendance. It's currently the best result any Sheffield secondary has achieved under the stricter framework rolled out in 2026, making it a useful reference point for what inspectors are rewarding this cycle. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *Worth a look as a comparator if you're benchmarking your own inspection preparation against what's currently scoring well locally.*

▪ **Sheffield joins near-90-council scheme to tackle NEET numbers.** Confirmed this week, the move brings councils, schools, colleges, employers, health services and community organisations together after figures showed Sheffield has one of England's higher NEET rates among 16-17 year-olds — part of the same national backdrop that saw NEET numbers pass one million earlier this year before easing slightly over the summer. It's a different story to High Storrs' inspection result above, but both are this week's reminder that outcomes vary sharply across the city's schools and post-16 pathways. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *Worth a conversation with your careers lead about how the scheme will touch your post-16 transition and destinations tracking.*

DATAPOINT – £174,000

The new cap on academy trust chief executive pay, binding from 1 October. Schools Week's analysis found 182 trusts paid their CEO above this threshold last year — that's now the figure any newly advertised post above it needs DfE sign-off to match or exceed.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics

Source	Type	What we track
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.